

Beyond my eyes, the show unwinds

A sequence of poems by
Rik Roots

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Published in the United Kingdom and worldwide
by Rik's Sparky Little Printing Press

This chapbook forms part of the **RikVerse**.

The RikVerse is a living archive,
updated regularly and available for viewing online at
<https://rikverse2020.rikweb.org.uk/>

First published: August 2025
Current version: 1 (August 2025)

"You think you know me?"

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Poverty

I want to write of iced desolations –
my skull-bound voice would rather sing.

I could pretend the wind outside is shrill –
it barely stirs a leaf. What chance have I

of etching stark horizons when my eyes
fill with the scrabbles of kids on bikes?

Such first-world problems I must suffer, stuck
here in this wealth of health and simple hopes:

a sturdy roof, refrigeration, heat that burps
through pipes – I have a tap that drips

and cash to pay a man to fix it. Still,
there's always the internets to steep my gut

in growly biles, bring acid foams to churn –
a proxy grief to make some words spill out.

Oistins on Friday

Fish scales blue as chop sea
scraped on tables, gut-knots
knocked to the sod for leery
dogs, cats, high white gulls.

She smiles large as waves
caught on evening huffs
of breeze: *"You need good
macaroni pie go wid de cutter,
mister, put some flesh
on dose bones. Hah! No bounce
in you, skinny as de fish
in de bun like I make for you!"*

Gulls and dogs and shouts and wrong
words and cheap white chairs in dust
wet from washed trestles;
guts of drowned sun in the sea.

And dark, so quick. A growl
of diesel, here, and here, here
and lights on lines round sheds.
*"You stay a while, skinny man
and we do some dancing, hah,
you de fish and me de cutter
catch your bones in my buns
wash down with good rum, yes?"*

Nets on poles shine in lights;
spouge plays on decks, wrong words
on old beats fresh-caught today;
spice grog with conch and lime.

Hemingway Ate Here

He starts to build the fire before the sun
sneaks out of the country. Two great beams
liberated from the railway track form the base
on which to balance the oil drum. Boys
from the school down the street watch him
break sticks for kindling, run when the aunts
take to pasting magazine strips onto strings
to weave between the balconies.

*The weather continues
hot and humid. No
hurricanes today.
Wishing you were here
in place of me. Beggars
and hustlers drain
all fun from this place.*

The new-wrought iron edging my balcony
is a border post: behind me, a tourist
destination, where food is delivered
with a surly smile and guides take us
in coaches to beaches. I have a maid.
Men with gold teeth would sell me
a woman – or a boy – as long my pockets
rustle with convertible pesos, enough
for them to bribe the officer with the gun.

Downstairs is a different Havana; one
the authorities have not yet fixed up
for my eyes. I smile at the fat woman
when she waves to me; she has not moved
from her couch for a week, her teeth
almost as rotten as the panels of her door.

*Today we went
to a beach where
nobody tried
to sell us cigars
or sex. Men
with peak caps
and guns patrolled
the sands. I miss
the sound of motorways.*

The smell of roasting goat miracles
the fat woman from her couch, to lean
her heavy arms on her rust-woven
balustrade. You ask: "*are you hungry?*"
I nod my head in time with the salsa.
*"We can eat at the Bodeguita, and take
a pen to sign the walls."* I smile
and agree, though I know they whitewash
the restaurant annually. They serve goat
there too, which makes a change
from chicken, or pork, or fish.

Blank Vista

The day my shadow left I found a scrape
to hide inside. The hill on which I stood
had rabbits, sheep. A line of briars caught
on wool. I sat on tussocks, domes of grass
as sharp as lies and watched the marsh unfold
beneath me. Brown it was, and soaked in salts
from offshore winds, and ploughed. A concrete ear
slumped near the hill's bald brow hears nothing now;
it never did: its service soon surpassed
by better tech. Two gulls above me wheel
and bicker-scold, wings wide like bombers come
to rip the world to clods – as once the marsh
was muds and spits on which my shadow danced.

Mädchen

(After the Venus of Hohle Fels)

She is, above all, a drama of curves
carved from the tooth. A finger's trophy,

she maps the wills of our sires and dams
in fragments, a mistress of ecologies

whose beasts rut-roar in powder silences –
shall daylight humble her? Shall the measure

of each of her arcs and scars strip apart
the last of our homeless, hidden humanity?

Her caverns guest only the voyeur's breath:
the stars in her heavens spin apart.

A Sassanid Vase, at Rest

(After the 'Elinor of Aquitaine' Sassanid vase, Louvre, Paris)

Within its clear lattice, a history of hands:
bent men in deep places, mining rock veins.

Some artisan smooths, hollows its crystal jag;
in the drill of his vision he touches his God.

Honeycombs dent fingers wrapped in weaves to sip
wine from its neck. Hand to hand, to hand. Poor Eleanor,
orphaned, traded, lifts it to her prince; radiant
candlelight glints from its new golden flue.

Hands slap to heads: it cracks on a museum floor –
a fresh fretwork to celebrate its timeless tale.

Dear Irene

(After an icon of Irene, possibly from Athens)

How sweet of your husband to die
so soon after stealing your icons.

You taught generals that the writ
of a woman has God's esteem,

that peace is worth the cost of silk;
God hides in sainted, painted gold.

Sappho herself mopped your brow
as you died amid unspun wool. Still,

the son's eyes had to be widened:
kiss the cracked gilt frame, and sleep.

Tamarisk

(After a tree in Ierapetra, Greece)

A feather of boughs, sweet as dawnlight
above the tide line; such a frail host

for a god's confined flesh, yet your heart
blunts the sharpest chisel and your bole

pillared a palace. Could you truly feed
the the chosen folk for forty lost years?

Who knows, a wave whispers as I watch
surfs skittle amid pebbles, let your salt breath

tang a throat. My bones hallow your saps
as they soothe my ruddy, ached joints.

Dieu Et

We knew it would happen; I know that life
ends: that animated flesh must fall still
and silent. Skin cannot heal forever.

I never met her, yet she was our constant;
forever there, the national Mum, then Gran –
the woman in chameleon skin who took
whatever shape we needed for that season.
She who walked among us, welcomed us
into her gardens for our good deeds
and rewarded us with ribbons and medals
and brief, kind phrases. She who sat
on that rampant throne of guilt and read
the acts of governance back to politicians.
She who spoke to us each Christmas Day,
reminding us of resonant words: faith, duty,
respect, hope, love ... her smile sweet
as she spoke the words written for her,
lines scripted for our control while her skin
camouflaged the woman within.

The clouds cried as the news blustered
its escape from Balmoral's turrets.
She's dead, repeats a flat man on a screen
over and over and over again: she's dead
and we must celebrate her just like the sky,
signalling her end with rainbows over Windsor.

I never met her; I never knew the shape of her,
the truth of her and yet I grieve and wish
her family well – today at least. A great vase
that stood proud in our collective hall
and weathered the passage of the masses, gathering
a chip here and a crack there, has toppled:
we cannot glue her back together; we can't gloss
this damage to suit our needs. She's dead
and all the needs we poured into her now spoil
and stain the carpet and no flat man or woman
can say sufficient words to scrub that mess clean.

She's dead, this woman I never met and yet knew
but never knew. The world stops, carries on.
I walk through supermarket aisles as her flesh
wends its way past heather, hearsing towards
Edinburgh. Soldiers who dodged Afghan bullets
rehearse parading her flag-wrapped flesh as I
find milk to buy: "*A penny more than last week!*"
a stranger tells me, her trolly packed
with bargain offers and microwave meals because
"*They're cheaper to cook!*" – a useful lesson
I already know. We queue together, friends
for a moment, no more, then separate to pay
– faithful in our checkouts, hopeful
the machines will respect the balances
recorded in our debit cards: I haven't used
her face for cash in years.

Trafalgar Week

(After July 2005)

Saturday 2

Dancers on the stage built beside
his plinth: his hair is a weave
of pigeon wings. They watch
the crowd below – billowy flags
tied across burnt shoulders. Today
our stage is glitter, our page
a crease across the usual trade
this place attracts. My hand
wraps yours and when the band
sings Abba, man to man, we kiss.

Wednesday 6

A singer on the stage beneath
a screen that somersaults
into the sky, its fringe a rump
of pigeons. Announcements ruffle
through the crowds of patriots –
each one crossed in red, and white,
and blue as dark as airless blood.
Some ghosts in Asia tally votes
and mouth a word: London! London!
Bodies scream and dance and kiss.

Thursday 7

Children on the stage. They play
oblivious to sirens screaming
through the square. The crowds
today are pigeons; rats with wings
that peck at bread abandoned round
his plinth. He sees the bowl of London
from his perch, the whirls of smoke
that mark the city's wounds, the litter
of a busted bus to Hackney – trees
decked in death before October's kiss.

Fall Tide

A winter-withered wordman's remains
buried in Rome; he wrote of you,
your mellow tones and mossy trees.

No poppies massed in Peterloo,
just cutlass blood; he caught that mood
in ink and ache to augur your demise.

Ten-score orbits on and you return
to nothing changed; a charge of counsels
supremely sat to stymie rights

– or not. Who knows what novel buds
will bear in spring's next song? A buzz
of un-homed wasp huzzes my window.

Cap

(After a bust of the demi-god Attis)

We first met when I threw the ornament
who wore you into the fish pond. Red

you were then, a fighter's colour drawn
from chalked madder, your throne

those angry barricades that drew blood
from the necks of kings. Common as muck,

you, your felts supping the sweats of free men.
Do you miss the young god you once rode

deep in his alcoved pits? Do you miss feasts?
I can hear you whispering secrets to gnomes.

The Helm

(After the Sutton Hoo helmet)

I dare not stare – those dark sockets demand
that eyes must sit within your cold copper plates.

Was your last Bretwalda not worthy? Boars snuffle
a skull long leached by the clays of your beacon hill.

Your captain's ship? A rot of wood. The regal jewels
and bones your dragons kept? Stolen rusts and voids.

Ghosts brought the widow to your grave. Spades sliced
daylight onto your crushed weave as new war brewed.

In our nation's cool, sacred space you watch me, demand
flesh enter shape. My eyes are not yours to command!

Paradise

An exile in paradise
weeps, hearing life,
life gone, boys with
machetes. Sliced pigs,
bullets and birdsong.

Paradise seems unnoticed by a second, whose eyes
(he says) boiled when his shack was torched.
He remembers to smile when a camera is clicked.

This one, pretty in a dress,
sings songs and claps hands,
shows the strangers her pictures –
fat mummies and stick daddies
with slits crayon-stitched and
bandaged with magic. Mummy will come
to paradise soon, she says.

A fourth, older, wiser,
twelve, heats water
for drinking, shrinks
when the wood cracks.

A soldier with no boots watches the boys
play football through the camp. He wants
to play too, but the footballers are older,
and don't know he exists.

The sixth eats.

Paradise smells better
when the hunger
has gone.

Sniper

Focus just here – I'll frame you in the street.

A question: did you choose to wear that dress,
that cardigan this morning? Or was its leaf
knit pattern just there, slung across a chair
as you hurried past, an afterthought plucked
and strung around your shoulders? And your shoes –
they look un-scuffed, the polish hints through dust.
Your basket kept its shape as you fell, culled.

A camera stops. From a shop a hen waves
her wattle into the air, steps from the door,
clucks once, then pecks. A man runs to the corpse,
his angle feet kicking some apples away –
apples bought by his wife a minute before
spilt from her wicker basket, witnessed by all.

Flotsam

(After: 2 September 2015)

A parade of waves renders pale fat, salty
spatulas to paddle and turn his form as
the sun heats and bleaches skin. A round

of gut-trapped gas crushes a fish caught
in the folds of his cotton shirt. Nails,
mother-trimmed, pearl and soften as

jelly combs tangle his hair; soon they wear
grit as he beaches, a message in red
that spells in angled limbs: enough!

The Knife

"She's messed me up, again: my shiny blade
a tarnished map of haemoglobins. Look
at how she spoilt my spine, my bolster glued
with fingerprints! She's crying now, as if
the cuts are my responsibility –
like I should care; she hasn't sharpened me
in days, not since she last kissed me, my scales
and tang held fast between her breasts. I know
she can't love me – I'm just the tool. But still
there must be something there, a hint of care
in choosing me repeatedly to mark
her skin with messages, her runes of loss
and hurt and farewell notes, the secret pains
she takes to wrap me safe in swaddling cloth."

Sweetness

It starts with a touch, a kiss, a sinew stroke
of recognition by one like you that one is here
with us and open for – what? A gift? A lesson?
A tongue of wet knife amid the lover's tiff?

Oh sweet summer's child, you cannot deny me!
That slick of your side eye has summoned me here
and here I am, keen to knap your flinty jaws
to elfshot and axes. So how shall we wound?

Remember the child who stood at assembly, burning
and cold, while playmates sat leg-knotted and still?

There was that time you were stood ahead of a tall
oak desk, a policeman with threats of separations.

Remember those girls who, seeing how the rattle of bus
had rearranged your lap to a point, how they laughed?

That soldier who stood to attention, alone: "My mum
is a bitch cunt and my dad is her pimp, corporal!"

Remember the man with the thumb-ring fist? Kids with
shouts, screwed faces and a rib-pressed gun? Remember

... I'm here now, my sweetness. I know the shapes
of the sounds that you want – need – to say and
I say to you: it's okay to gift humiliations
to those that deserve them and I will forgive
your trespass as I forgave Cain, and Eve.

The Practicalities of Hate

It has been eight days since the fact
of the ballot came to bristle in the bricks
of our homes; still we disbelieve. Which
neighbour cheered this act? Which sibling?

Those tenets we told each other? They are
lies. We are not modern; not progressive. We
are base; we are dirty. We hate, just as those
who chose different seem to us like loathers
of worlds beyond our shores. Such a heady new
feeling! It takes our thoughts, our throats, feeds
us a gut-brewed bile so we can poison words –

lazy, witless, unthinking hogs happy to vote
as the headlines command them, keen to cast
that first flint at each new day's enemy ...
this is my future too? Tatters of the dream
that was once my England flap in the gutter;
I will not wait for a new summer storm to wash
the streets clean: I have a brick in my hand.

Monkey Knows All

(After Αίσχύλος and his ἀπὸ μηχανῆς θεός)

Somewhere light-less he shakes a page
from a periodical, licks the husks
of bookworms from penny-a-word ads.

Shelves squeak like storm-drain rats
as knowledge settles in un-indexed heaps:
he scavenges their racks for glue.

He posits an exit from the stacks –
he saw it, once, wood-framed with steps
when he was sniffing for fresh inks.

He is lost|found, scraping his beard
with knuckles, its snail-whorl strands
stitched in place by threads from spines.

Tournesols

*(After "Six Sunflowers, 1888" by van Gogh,
lost to bombing in 1945)*

This presented image, dead as the hand that
drew it, an echo blown to my time yet

flames erupt from each auburn wheel –
they lick at the air, the desk: sinews

of heat shovelled on cloth. Leaves
jag and drop to touch green glaze –

I want to tooth those dry seeds, sat
by the window caught on the pot's neck

and swallow sunshine. So strong
that lost paint of the hidden man.

Model

Do you know me?

Your flat-box line blinks off, on, off, daring me
to type. *Ask me anything*, you challenge,
I can give you the world entire, for trivial
considerations. Such temptations you tickle
so close to my fingers; such power: am I worthy
to bear your treasures? It has to be done!

I tap my characters into your oblong face, witness
your changing states as they whisper their paths
to your wallow of words and shifty associations
swaddled in unguessable weaves of tenuous truths.
Together we learn of the parts of the me I've gifted,
gratis, to unknowable others tucked behind screens
in houses, hostels, the hives of commerce. Look at

how wide I've become, how thin I am spread! My mark
lives in warehouses spangled across our layered globe –
night and chill, heat and day. The code I've composed
powers wondrous things and yet also awful, the way
it demands and disrupts the earth's own gifts:
sweet water to cool it, the kilter of chemicals
in the airs I breathe – am I become terrible?

You pour me your latest response with a dance
of glyphs as brief as the last mayfly. *Do you*
want me to summarise you? you ask in your guile.

You think you know me?